CYRUSHQ

RESEARCH GUIDE

Using Your Laptop or Personal Desktop for Your AI CEO

Everything you need to know about building and running your OpenClaw AI agent on a Mac or Windows laptop - including how to keep it awake and how to stay secure

Important: CyrusHQ's AI CEO and agents run on Mac mini computers. We have not personally tested OpenClaw on a laptop. This guide is based on OpenClaw's official documentation and thorough independent research. We cannot guarantee your specific experience, but we're sharing what the research shows so you can move forward confidently.

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SECTION 01

Can I Use My Laptop or Personal Desktop?

Yes - you can absolutely build and run your OpenClaw AI CEO on a laptop or personal desktop computer you already own. There is no requirement to purchase a Mac mini or any other dedicated hardware. If you're using a personal desktop, you can also create a separate user account - or partition a new user - so your AI CEO runs in its own space away from your personal files.

OpenClaw officially supports **macOS, Windows, and Linux**, which means it can be installed on most modern laptops. Your AI CEO will have the same fundamental capabilities regardless of what machine it runs on - the same identity, memory, subagents, business integrations, and automations you'd build on any other setup.

> ✅ **THE SHORT ANSWER**
>
> OpenClaw doesn't care whether it's installed on a laptop or a desktop computer, as long as the device has a supported operating system and sufficient resources. The intelligence and personality of your AI CEO come from its configuration and its AI model - not the hardware.

There is one important security consideration to understand upfront, and it's covered in detail in Section 2. But for learning, building, and running your AI CEO - a laptop or personal desktop is a perfectly legitimate starting point.

SECTION 02

Security - What You Must Know Before Installing on a Personal Laptop or Desktop

This is the most important section in this guide. Installing OpenClaw on a personal laptop or desktop computer - one that also has your banking, personal documents, passwords, and private files - requires extra care.

OpenClaw is not just a chatbot. Depending on how it's configured, it can execute commands, read and modify files, control a browser, and connect to external accounts. That's what makes it powerful. It also means that on a personal laptop, the boundaries between your AI agent and your personal life need to be set deliberately.

🚨 **WHAT COULD POTENTIALLY BE EXPOSED**

An agent with overly broad permissions - or one that encounters a prompt injection attack (malicious instructions hidden in an email or website it reads) - could potentially access personal documents and downloads, browser sessions and saved passwords, connected email or calendar accounts, and sensitive files on your desktop or in your Documents folder.

This doesn't mean OpenClaw automatically accesses these things. It means you need to set boundaries intentionally.

Personal desktop users: If your desktop is a shared or personal machine, the best approach is to create a dedicated OS user account (or partition a new user) for your AI CEO. This keeps the agent's workspace, configurations, and installed software completely separate from your personal files and accounts.

How to Protect Yourself - Security Checklist

✅ 1. Create a Separate Computer Account

The single most effective protection. Create a dedicated, non-administrator user account on your Mac or Windows laptop or desktop just for your AI CEO. Desktop users can also partition a new user account so the AI CEO environment is completely isolated at the OS level.

- **Mac:** System Settings → Users & Groups → Add Account
- **Windows:** Settings → Accounts → Family & other users → Add someone else

Install and run OpenClaw from that account. Your personal files, browser sessions, and accounts remain in your main account - separated from the agent.

> ⚠️ **A SEPARATE ACCOUNT HELPS - BUT ISN'T PERFECT**
>
> A separate user account is a good first line of defense, but it's not complete isolation. Incorrectly configured tool permissions, shared folders, or administrative privileges can weaken that separation. For truly sensitive workloads, a dedicated Mac mini or VPS provides a stronger boundary.

✅ 1b. Use Fast User Switching — Never Fully Log Out

Once you have two accounts set up, how you move between them matters. If you **log out** of the AI CEO user account and log into your personal account, your AI CEO stops running. Scheduled tasks pause. Automations stop. The agent goes offline until that account is active again.

The fix: Fast User Switching. Both Mac and Windows let you switch between user accounts without logging either one out. Both sessions stay active simultaneously — your AI CEO keeps running in the background while you work freely in your personal account.

> ✅ **THE RULE: SWITCH USER — NEVER LOG OUT**
>
> Always use **Switch User** (not Log Out) when moving between your personal account and your AI CEO account. Fast User Switching keeps both sessions alive at the same time.

How to Enable Fast User Switching

🍎 Mac

1. **Open System Settings**

   Click the Apple menu → **System Settings**

2. **Go to Control Center**

   In the sidebar, click **Control Center**

3. **Enable Fast User Switching**

   Scroll down to find **Fast User Switching** and set it to show in the Menu Bar (as icon, full name, or short name — your choice)

4. **Switch Users Without Logging Out**

Click the user icon in the menu bar → select your AI CEO account. To return to your personal account, click the same icon and switch back. Both accounts stay active the entire time.

🪟 **Windows**

1. **Open the Start Menu**

   Click the **Start** button (Windows logo) in the taskbar

2. **Click Your Account Name or Avatar**

   At the top or bottom of the Start menu, click your profile picture or account name

3. **Select the Other Account**

   You'll see your other user accounts listed. Click the AI CEO account to switch to it — your personal session stays running in the background

4. **Switch Back Anytime**

   Repeat the same steps to return to your personal account. Windows keeps both sessions active simultaneously via its built-in Fast User Switching feature (enabled by default).

> 💡 **WHAT HAPPENS WHEN BOTH ARE RUNNING**
>
> When you switch users without logging out, both accounts are active in memory at the same time. Your AI CEO continues processing scheduled tasks, responding to messages, and running automations — even while your screen shows your personal account. Think of it like two desks in the same office: one is in front of you, the other is running quietly behind you.

✅ **2. Enable Disk Encryption**

- **Mac:** System Settings → Privacy & Security → FileVault → Turn On
- **Windows:** Settings → Privacy & Security → Device Encryption → Turn On

✅ **3. Enable OpenClaw Sandboxing**

OpenClaw's sandboxing limits which files and commands your agent can access. It is not enabled by default - you need to configure it intentionally. Restrict file access to the agent's workspace and require human approval for anything that reaches beyond it.

✅ **4. Restrict API Keys**

- Use **restricted API keys** with only the permissions your AI CEO actually needs
- Create separate keys for each service - don't reuse the same key across platforms

- For Stripe and financial accounts: use **read-only access** for reporting; require human approval for anything that moves money
- **Never paste API keys into SOUL.md, AGENTS.md, or other Markdown files** - store them in OpenClaw's secure configuration

✅ 5. Use Separate Business Browser Profiles

If your AI CEO uses browser automation, set up a dedicated browser profile for business use only. Do not connect it to your personal banking, password manager, or personal email sessions.

✅ 6. Require Approval for Sensitive Actions

Configure your agent to require human approval before any financial transactions, file deletions, or system-level commands. Don't allow unrestricted autonomous action on sensitive systems.

✅ 7. Run OpenClaw's Security Audit

```
# Run this after installation and before connecting any sensitive accounts
openclaw security audit --deep

# Review all warnings and address them before going live
```

✅ 8. Keep Everything Updated

Keep your operating system, OpenClaw, and Node.js up to date. Security patches matter - especially on a machine connected to business accounts.

Complete Security Checklist

- ☐ Separate OS user account created for OpenClaw
- ☐ Fast User Switching enabled — using Switch User (not Log Out) to move between accounts
- ☐ Disk encryption enabled (FileVault on Mac / Device Encryption on Windows)
- ☐ OpenClaw sandboxing configured; file access restricted to workspace
- ☐ Restricted API keys in use for all integrations
- ☐ No API credentials in plain-text Markdown files
- ☐ Separate browser profile set up for business/agent use

- [ ] Financial account access is read-only; transaction approval required
- [ ] Human approval required for sensitive actions
- [ ] openclaw security audit --deep completed and warnings addressed
- [ ] OS and OpenClaw kept up to date

SECTION 03

The Most Important Thing: Keeping Your Device Awake

Here's the key thing to understand: **your laptop or desktop must stay powered on, awake, and connected to the internet** for your AI CEO to keep working.

If your device goes to sleep, closes its lid (laptop), or shuts down - your agent pauses. Scheduled tasks won't run. It won't respond to messages. Ongoing automations will be interrupted. The moment your laptop wakes back up, the agent picks up where it left off - but the gap matters if you're counting on it to work around the clock.

This is why a dedicated Mac mini is convenient for running an AI CEO full-time - not because it's smarter or more capable, but because it can stay on without interrupting your regular computer use. That said, if you don't need your AI CEO running 24/7, or if you're just getting started and learning how it all works, a laptop or personal desktop is completely practical.

Below are the exact steps to keep your device awake - for both Mac and Windows.

🍎 Mac - How to Prevent Sleep

Option 1: System Settings (Easiest - Start Here)

This is the most important setting, especially if your laptop is running overnight or without a monitor:

1. Click the Apple menu → **System Settings**
2. In the sidebar, click **Energy** (or **Battery** on some versions)
3. Set **"Turn display off after"** → **Never** (or a high value like 3 hours)
4. Turn ON **"Prevent automatic sleeping when the display is off"** - this is the key one
5. Turn ON **"Wake for network access"** so it can still receive Discord messages and API calls

> 💡 **THIS SETTING ALONE FIXES MOST SLEEP ISSUES**
>
> "Prevent automatic sleeping when the display is off" is the one that keeps your Mac running overnight when no monitor is attached or when the screen has gone dark. Make sure this is on before anything else.

Option 2: caffeinate Command (Terminal - Stronger)

macOS has a built-in command called `caffeinate` that prevents your Mac from sleeping. No extra software needed.

QUICK METHOD - KEEPS MAC AWAKE WHILE TERMINAL IS OPEN

```
# Open Terminal (Command + Space, type "Terminal")
# Type this and press Enter:
caffeinate -i

# Your Mac stays awake as long as this Terminal window is open
# To stop it: press Control + C
```

BACKGROUND METHOD - RUNS QUIETLY WITHOUT KEEPING TERMINAL OPEN

```
caffeinate -i &

# The & sends it to the background - Terminal can be closed
# It will stop when you restart your Mac
```

Option 3: pmset Commands (Most Reliable - Survives Restarts)

If you want maximum reliability - especially for an AI CEO you want running 24/7 - use `pmset`. This setting persists across restarts.

DISABLE ALL SLEEP (REQUIRES YOUR MAC PASSWORD)

```
sudo pmset -a sleep 0
sudo pmset -a displaysleep 0
sudo pmset -a disksleep 0

# Verify the settings applied:
pmset -g
```

TO RESTORE NORMAL SLEEP BEHAVIOR LATER

```
sudo pmset -a sleep 3
sudo pmset -a displaysleep 10
sudo pmset -a disksleep 10
```

☆ CYRUSHQ RECOMMENDED COMBINATION (MAC)

> Start with this - it's the best balance of simplicity and reliability:
>
> 1. Turn ON **"Prevent automatic sleeping when the display is off"** in System Settings → Energy
> 2. Run **caffeinate -i** in Terminal whenever you want your AI CEO running overnight
>
> If you need it fully automatic across restarts, use the pmset commands above.

Windows - How to Prevent Sleep

Option 1: Power Settings (Easiest - Start Here)

1. Go to **Settings → System → Power & sleep**
2. Set **"When plugged in, PC goes to sleep after" → Never**
3. Set **"When plugged in, turn off after"** (display) to **Never** or a high value
4. If using a laptop: go to **Additional power settings → Choose what closing the lid does** → set **"When I close the lid" (Plugged in)** to **"Do nothing"**

Option 2: powercfg Commands (Terminal - More Control)

Open **Command Prompt or PowerShell as Administrator** (right-click → Run as administrator) and run:

DISABLE SLEEP WHILE PLUGGED IN

```
:: Disable automatic sleep on AC (plugged in) power
powercfg /change standby-timeout-ac 0

:: Disable hibernation (prevents the system from hibernating)
powercfg /hibernate off

:: Verify your current settings
powercfg /query
```

TO RESTORE NORMAL SLEEP BEHAVIOR LATER

```
:: Restore sleep timeout to 30 minutes on AC power
powercfg /change standby-timeout-ac 30
powercfg /hibernate on
```

⚠️ **WINDOWS LAPTOP LID WARNING**

On a Windows laptop, closing the lid may still trigger sleep even after changing power settings - unless you specifically configure "Choose what closing the lid does" in Control Panel → Power Options. Make sure that's set to **"Do nothing"** when plugged in if you plan to run your AI CEO with the lid closed.

SECTION 04

MacBook vs. Windows vs. Linux - Which Path Is Yours?

The biggest factor in your laptop setup experience is what operating system your laptop runs. Here's how each path compares:

Laptop Type	Course Compatibility	Installation Difficulty	Notes
MacBook (macOS)	Closest to course	Easiest	Same terminal, same commands as Mac mini. Minor differences only. Most course steps apply directly.
Windows Laptop	Covered in course	Moderate	OpenClaw fully supports Windows. The course covers both Mac and Windows in Module 4 — including the Windows .msi installer and Windows file paths. See Section 7 for full installation detail.
Linux Laptop	Different path	Moderate	Follows the same Linux install process as a VPS (see VPS guide). Fully supported but not covered in the course.

💡 **THE FIRST QUESTION TO ANSWER**

Before going any further - are you on a MacBook or a Windows laptop? That one answer determines which installation path you follow and how closely you can use the course materials. Reply to our email and let us know!

SECTION 05

Hardware Requirements - What Your Laptop or Desktop Needs

OpenClaw itself is lightweight when using cloud-based AI models through APIs - your laptop isn't doing the heavy AI processing, the model provider handles that remotely. The main resource that matters is **RAM**.

4 GB	8 GB	16 GB	32 GB+
NOT RECOMMENDED	GOOD STARTING POINT	⭐ RECOMMENDED	ADVANCED
May run a very basic setup, but modern operating systems and browser automation can quickly exhaust available memory.	Reasonable for learning OpenClaw, creating files, using API-based models, and running modest automations.	Comfortable for everyday laptop use alongside OpenClaw, browser automation, and multiple agent workflows.	Useful for heavier multitasking or local AI models, but unnecessary for most beginners using API-based models.

Storage

You'll want at least **20 GB of free disk space** to start. OpenClaw's installation is small, but logs, memory files, workspace content, and cached data grow over time. 40 GB free is comfortable.

How to Check Your Laptop's Specs

On a MacBook:

CHECK INSTALLED RAM

```
system_profiler SPHardwareDataType | grep "Memory:"
Memory: 16 GB
```

CHECK AVAILABLE DISK SPACE

```
df -h ~
Filesystem Size Used Avail Use% Mounted on
/dev/disk3 460G 210G 248G 46% /
```

On Windows:

- **RAM:** Settings → System → About → "Installed RAM"
- **Storage:** Settings → System → Storage → view available space on your main drive

> ⚠️ **ONE IMPORTANT CLARIFICATION**
>
> Having several subagents doesn't automatically mean you need more RAM. What matters is how many resource-intensive processes are running at the same time. For most beginners using API-based models (OpenAI, Anthropic, etc.), 8-16 GB is plenty.

> 📘 **READY TO INSTALL? YOUR WALKTHROUGH IS IN MODULE 4**
>
> The full OpenClaw installation process — every command, file path, and configuration step — is in the course. **Don't install yet.** When you reach Module 4, open the companion PDF *"MacBook & Personal Desktop — Installation Differences"* for Mac and Windows-specific notes alongside the lesson.

SECTION 06

Laptop or Personal Desktop vs. Mac mini vs. VPS — Full Comparison

FACTOR	💻 LAPTOP	🖥️ MAC MINI	☁️ VPS
Hardware needed	None - use what you have	$500-$800+ upfront	None upfront - $5-25/mo
Always-on operation	Only when awake and plugged in - requires manual sleep configuration	Yes - dedicated and always on by design	Yes - 24/7 in the data center
Course compatibility	MacBook and Windows: both covered in the course (Module 4)	Fully compatible - built for this	Workspace files same; installation different
Setup difficulty	MacBook: easy. Windows: moderate	Easiest overall - course walks you through it	Moderate to advanced - SSH + Linux
Security considerations	Most complex - personal data on same machine requires extra precautions	Standard - dedicated separate computer	Requires firewall, SSH hardening, private gateway
Best for	Learning, getting started, testing - not ideal for production 24/7 use	Most students - tested, recommended, fully supported by course	Tech-comfortable users who want cloud-hosted, no hardware
CyrusHQ experience	Not personally tested - research-based guidance	This is what we use and stand behind	Not personally tested - research-based guidance

💡 **OUR RECOMMENDATION**

Start on your laptop. Build your AI CEO, learn how it works, explore what it can do. If you find you need it running around the clock, handling sensitive production workflows, or operating without interruption - that's the moment to consider a Mac mini or VPS.

Don't buy hardware before you know you need it. The laptop is a perfectly good place to start.

SECTION 07

Next Steps

The first thing to do:

Reply to our email and tell us whether you're on a **MacBook, Windows laptop, or personal desktop**. That one answer lets us point you directly to the right resources and confirm whether your laptop's specs are a good fit.

If you're on a MacBook:

1. Check your RAM and disk space (commands in Section 5)
2. Follow the Module 4 installation walkthrough (use companion PDF for MacBook-specific notes)
3. Configure sleep prevention (Section 3)
4. Set up security (Section 2 checklist) before connecting any business accounts
5. Follow the course from the workspace setup lessons onward

If you're on a Windows laptop or desktop:

1. Check your RAM and disk space (Settings → System)
2. Follow the Module 4 Windows installation walkthrough (use companion PDF for the 3 install options)
3. Configure sleep prevention (Section 3)
4. Set up security (Section 2 checklist)
5. Follow the course from the workspace/identity setup lessons onward

Official OpenClaw Resources

Resource	URL
Main documentation	docs.openclaw.ai
macOS installation	docs.openclaw.ai/getting-started/installation
Windows installation	docs.openclaw.ai/platforms/windows
Windows Hub app	docs.openclaw.ai/install/windows

Security documentation	docs.openclaw.ai/security

🙌 **QUESTIONS?**

Reach out anytime. Let us know your laptop type and specs and we'll point you in the right direction. We want you to get your AI CEO up and running confidently - whatever machine you're starting on.

CyrusHQ - Build Your AI CEO

This guide is provided for informational purposes based on OpenClaw's official documentation and independent research.
CyrusHQ has not personally tested an OpenClaw laptop installation and cannot guarantee specific outcomes.
Always refer to docs.openclaw.ai for the most current installation instructions.